INDIGENOUS-INSPIRED SHRIMP 'N' GRITS

serves 4

In much of the Southeast, as well as other parts of Turtle Island, cornmeal-based porridges were a staple for Indigenous peoples and still are today.

This recipe is an homage to the Southern classic that has its roots in Africa and was likely first cooked in the United States by African cooks in the Carolina Lowcountry.

Rich with smoked turkey and fresh corn, these shrimp 'n' grits take some time to put together. To build flavor for the gravy, you need to make a stock using shrimp shells and husked ears of corn. You can then thicken it with filé powder, which is made with sassafras leaves and popular in gumbo (see page 144).

- 1 pound large shell-on wild shrimp (16/20 count)
- 3 large ears sweet corn, husked
- 4 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 8 ramps or scallions, 4 coarsely chopped and 4 thinly sliced crosswise
- 2 red bay leaves or other bay leaves
- 1 cup coarse-ground grits
- Sea salt
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- Pinch of red pepper flakes
- 4 Roma tomatoes, cored and coarsely chopped
- 1 teaspoon ground sumac
- Meat from 1 smoked turkey drumstick or 2 smoked duck legs, cut into bite-size pieces
- ½ teaspoon filé powder (optional)
- Nasturtium leaves, for garnish (optional)

Peel and devein the shrimp. Reserve the shrimp shells and refrigerate the shrimp until you need them.

Cut the kernels from 1 ear of the corn, reserving the cob and kernels separately.

Use the large holes of a box grater to grate the kernels from the remaining 2 ears of corn. Reserve the cobs and grated corn separately.

In a medium saucepan, heat 2 tablespoons of the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Add the shrimp shells and coarsely chopped ramps and cook for about 8 minutes, or until the shells are crisped and pink and the ramps are very tender and browned in spots.

Add the 3 corncobs, 4 cups water, and the red bay leaves and bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low, cover, and simmer for about 1 hour, or until the stock is flavorful and reduced to about 1½ cups. Strain into a large measuring cup, discarding the solids.

Meanwhile, in a medium saucepan, bring 4½ cups water to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to low and gradually stir in the grits and 1 teaspoon salt. Cook for 45 minutes to 1 hour, until the grits are creamy and tender, stirring occasionally and being sure to scrape the bottom of the pot.

Stir the grated corn into the grits and keep warm.

When ready to serve, in a large skillet, heat the remaining 2 tablespoons of oil over medium heat until shimmering. Add the shrimp in a single layer and cook for about 2 minutes, or until nearly opaque. Stir and cook until the shrimp are opaque throughout, about 1 minute longer. Use a slotted spoon to transfer them to a plate.

Add the thinly sliced ramps to the skillet, season with salt, and cook for about 3 minutes, or just until softened. Add the garlic and pepper flakes and cook for about 1 minute, or until fragrant. Add the tomatoes and

sumac and cook for about 10 minutes, or until the tomato juices release and nearly evaporate.

Add the reserved 1½ cups shrimp/corn stock and bring to a boil over high heat. Cook, stirring a few times, until reduced by half. Reduce the heat to medium, stir in the smoked turkey and whole corn kernels, and cook for about 2 minutes to warm through.

Add the filé powder, if desired, and cook just until the sauce thickens a bit more. Taste and season with salt. Return the shrimp to the skillet and stir to coat and heat through.

Taste the grits and season with more salt as needed. To serve, ladle the grits into bowls. Top with the shrimp and gravy and nasturtium, if using.